

FOR THE WOMAN DATING WITH A CHILD

WILL HE STILL WANT ME WITH A CHILD?

The right one will.
Stop apologising for your child, and start
choosing who deserves to meet them.



THE CONNECTION CODE

Contents

Before You Start.....	4
INTRODUCTION: Addressed To You.....	4
Fifteen years of being the topic.....	4
What that does to how you date.....	5
What this book is for.....	5
What it will not do.....	6
CHAPTER 1: You Have Been Reading The Threads.....	7
What the threads actually are.....	7
What they cost you.....	7
The count that matters more.....	8
What you actually know.....	8
What this chapter changes.....	8
CHAPTER 2: Why Proving Yourself Does Not Work.....	9
The four moves.....	9
Why it feels like the safe option.....	9
The swap.....	10
The sentence you wrote down.....	10
What this chapter changes.....	10
CHAPTER 3: The Men Who Disqualify Themselves In Week One.....	12
The six early tells.....	12
Testing number four deliberately.....	13
What the filter is really buying you.....	13
What this chapter changes.....	14
CHAPTER 4: Telling Him.....	15
Three rules before the wording.....	15
The warm version.....	15
The firm version.....	16
What he does next.....	16
What this chapter changes.....	17
CHAPTER 5: The Questions That Come After.....	18
What he's entitled to ask.....	18
What he isn't entitled to.....	18
Answering the fair ones.....	19
Declining the rest.....	19
When the questions are actually a pattern.....	20
What this chapter changes.....	20
CHAPTER 6: Your Child Is Not A Milestone.....	21
Why it happens too early.....	21
The readiness test.....	21
Holding the line when he asks.....	22

The first meeting, when it comes.....	22
When your child doesn't take to him.....	23
What this chapter changes.....	23
CHAPTER 7: The Six-Month Rule.....	24
Why six.....	24
The checklist.....	24
The conversation with a man who is waiting well.....	25
When the rule is the problem.....	25
What this chapter changes.....	26
IN PRACTICE: Four Months, Start To Finish.....	27
Week one.....	27
Weeks two and three.....	27
Week four.....	27
Week six.....	28
Month three.....	28
Month four.....	29
Where it goes from there.....	29
CHAPTER 8: When He Will Not Choose You.....	30
The man who stays and never commits.....	30
Ending it.....	30
What you tell your child.....	31
The other parent, and where this book stops.....	31
The thing that is actually true.....	32
What this chapter changes.....	32
CONCLUSION: The Room You Were Never In.....	33
What changed.....	33
Tonight.....	33

Before You Start

This book is not a pep talk and it is not an argument with the men on Nairaland.

It doesn't tell you the stigma isn't real. It is real, you've met it, and a book that opens by denying it has already lost you.

What it does is simpler. It hands you the decisions that are actually yours, in the order you'll face them, with the words to go with each one. The scripts use a four-year-old daughter as the example. Put in your own child's name and age, and "son" where it fits.

ABOUT THE PEOPLE QUOTED HERE

Everyone quoted here is real and spoke on the record, either to a Nigerian publication or on a podcast the Nigerian press reported. Names and ages appear as published. Nothing has been invented, and where a source could not be verified it was removed rather than used.

ONE THING THIS BOOK WILL NOT DO

It will not advise you on your child's father. Custody, access and maintenance are legal matters with real consequences, and a PDF is the wrong instrument. Chapter 8 says where that belongs.

INTRODUCTION: Addressed To You

The Nigerian publication Zikoko ran a feature on dating someone who has a child. Five Nigerians, named, with their ages.

Femi, 32. Wale, 44. Henry, 52. Lami, 30. Sarah, 29.

Three men dating women with children. Two women dating men with children.

Not one of the five was the parent.

A whole feature about your situation, and nobody thought to ask the person it's actually happening to. That isn't malice. It's the shape of the entire conversation, and once you've seen it you'll notice it everywhere.

Fifteen years of being the topic

Go to Nairaland, Nigeria's biggest forum, and search. The threads have titles like *Would You Date Or Marry A Single Mother. Challenges Of Marrying A Single Mom. What Are The Disadvantages In Marrying A Baby Mama. Is It Advisable To Marry A Single Mother. Is This True About Some Single Mothers.*

They run from 2011 to this year. Some are twenty-five pages long. And it isn't only Nigeria. You'll find the same questions in Facebook groups and comment sections wherever you are on the continent.

Read the titles again and notice the grammar. Every one of them is a question about you, asked by somebody else, answered by strangers. You can read the whole debate. You were never invited into it.

Pulse has a piece called *Why dating a Single Mom is hard*. Hard for whom. The title answers that before you open it.

THE THING TO SEE BEFORE ANYTHING ELSE

You have spent years reading an argument about your own worth, conducted by people who were never going to be in your life, and you have been absorbing their conclusions as though they were information about you. They are not information about you. They are the opinions of strangers, published where you could see them.

What that does to how you date

Something specific, and you'll recognise it.

You disclose early and apologetically, to get the rejection over with. You over-explain your circumstances the first time it comes up. You feel grateful when a man is merely decent. You've caught yourself mentioning that your child is well-behaved, as though that were the point.

You're auditioning. Chapter 2 is about how to stop.

Kaffy, the Nigerian dancer and choreographer, is 45, divorced, and has two children. On The Honest Bunch podcast in 2025, she said:

"I have had somebody tell me because I'm a single mother, he can't even think of dating me because I have two children."

Her answer is the sentence this book is built around:

"What makes you think that a woman who has been divorced is not even the better candidate if she has worked on herself?"

What this book is for

Eight chapters, in the order the decisions actually arrive.

Who disqualifies himself early, so you screen before you're attached rather than after. How to tell him, in words that are neither an apology nor a challenge. Which questions about your child's father he's entitled to ask, and which he isn't. When he meets your child, which is the one decision in here you cannot take back.

Ten scripts, warm and firm, written to be said out loud or sent without editing, plus a worked example running the whole sequence across four months.

What it will not do

It won't argue with the threads. You could win that argument and still be where you are.

It won't promise you a husband. Nothing can, and anything that does is taking your money.

It won't tell you to hide your child. The opposite. Chapter 6 is about protecting them properly.

DO THIS NOW

Before Chapter 1, write down one sentence you've said on a first date that you wouldn't have said if you didn't have a child. Just one. You'll use it in Chapter 2.

Start with the threads.

CHAPTER 1: You Have Been Reading The Threads

You've read them. Possibly at 1am, possibly more than once.

What are the disadvantages in marrying a baby mama. Twenty-five pages of men you'll never meet, deciding in public whether women like you are acceptable, with the occasional one saying something kind in a tone that makes it worse.

You went looking for information. What you got was a verdict, and you've been carrying it since.

What the threads actually are

Three things worth knowing about that genre before you give it another minute.

They're written by the people with the least at stake. A man posting *Would you marry a single mother* is not deciding anything. He's performing a position for an audience of other men. The stakes for him are zero, which is exactly why he can be so certain.

They select for the loudest view. Forum threads reward the strongest opinion, not the most common one. The man quietly dating a woman with a child and finding it unremarkable has no reason to post. He isn't in the thread. He is, however, in the world.

They're old and they repeat. The same question in 2011, 2016, 2023 and 2026. Fifteen years of asking something nobody ever settles. A question that gets re-asked for fifteen years is not a question with an answer. It's a ritual.

THE MISTAKE THIS CHAPTER EXISTS TO STOP

Do not go back and read them again to see whether anything has changed. Nothing has changed, and that is the point. You will lose two hours and finish the night worse. If you have a Nairaland tab open right now, close it before Chapter 2.

What they cost you

Not feelings. Decisions.

Reading the appraisal for years teaches you to pre-empt it, and the pre-emption shows up in how you behave with real men who never said any of it.

You bring it up before he does. You explain more than the question asked for. You lower what you'll accept, because the threads told you your market is small. You interpret ordinary decency as generosity.

None of that came from any man you've actually dated. It came from strangers, and you imported it.

The count that matters more

Here's a number with real content in it, unlike anything in those threads.

Singles who want a serious relationship pay for help finding one. In August 2026, a Lagos pastor launched a Christian matchmaking platform with annual membership at ₦70,000, ₦350,000 and ₦700,000. The cheapest tier equals a full month at Nigeria's national minimum wage.

People are spending a month's minimum wage a year to meet someone serious. That's a market with more demand than supply, and you are a participant in it, not a supplicant to it.

THE REFRAME

The threads describe a shortage of men willing to date you. The prices describe a shortage of people who can find anybody at all. Both cannot be true, and only one of them has money behind it.

What you actually know

Strip out what you absorbed and keep what you've observed.

Write two lists tonight. On the left, what men have actually said or done to you about your child, in the last two years, first-hand. On the right, what you're afraid they think.

For most women the left list is shorter than expected, and thinner. Some of it is ugly and real. But it's usually two or three incidents doing the work of a hundred, because the threads supplied the rest.

YOUR MOVE

1. Two lists. Observed on the left, feared on the right.
2. Count the items on each.
3. Keep the page. Chapter 3 turns the left list into a filter.

What this chapter changes

You've stopped treating a fifteen-year forum argument as a finding about your life. The men in it were never going to be in it.

That's the easy half. The hard half is what you've been doing in response, which you'll recognise on the first page of the next chapter.

CHAPTER 2: Why Proving Yourself Does Not Work

Second date. He hasn't asked. You tell him anyway.

Then you keep going. Her father isn't in the picture, it ended badly but you're on fine terms, she's four, she's actually very well behaved, she stays with your mother on weekends so it wouldn't affect your time together, and you're not looking for anyone to be a father to her.

He said about nine words in that whole stretch.

You've just done the audition, and you did it beautifully, and it cost you.

The four moves

Every version of the audition uses some combination of these. You'll recognise at least two.

Disclosing before you're asked. Framed as honesty, which it partly is. But you do it early to get the rejection over with, and the effect is to put your child on the table as a problem to be assessed before he's had any chance to decide he likes you.

Pre-answering the objections. *She's well behaved. Her father isn't involved. It won't affect us.* Nobody raised these. Answering unasked objections tells him objections exist, and now he's looking for them.

Discounting yourself in advance. *I know it's a lot. I understand if that's not what you're looking for.* You've offered him an exit and framed it as considerate.

Over-giving to compensate. Paying more often than you can afford. Being more available than you want to be. Absorbing behaviour you wouldn't have absorbed at 24. This one is the most expensive and the hardest to see, because it feels like warmth.

WHAT EVERY ONE OF THOSE FOUR COMMUNICATES

Not that you are honest, or considerate, or low-maintenance. What they communicate, all four, is that you believe you are starting from behind. He will take that information and price accordingly. Most men are not cruel. They are just responsive.

Why it feels like the safe option

Because it protects you from one specific pain: being rejected later, after you've become attached, for something you could have disclosed at the start.

That fear is reasonable. The strategy built on it is not, because auditioning doesn't prevent that rejection. It just moves it earlier and adds a cost.

And the cost is real. You spend the early weeks establishing that you're worth the inconvenience, which means you never spend them finding out whether he's worth anything.

That's the trade you've been making. Less rejection, less information.

The swap

You're not going to become guarded. Guarded is just the audition with a different face, and it costs you the men who'd have been good.

You're going to swap the order.

Right now you disclose, then he evaluates, then you find out about him. From here it's: you find out about him, then you disclose, then you both decide.

That's the whole change. Nothing about honesty moves. The timing does.

What stays. You tell him before anything serious. You never lie or imply you're childless. You answer a direct question directly, the first time it's asked.

What goes. Volunteering it in the first hour. Answering objections nobody made. Apologising for your own life. Treating decency as a favour.

THE OVERCORRECTION

Having read this, some women swing to hiding it for two months to make him invest first. Do not. It reads as deception when it lands, it is unfair to him, and it puts you in exactly the position you were trying to avoid, this time deservedly. The shift is about order and tone. It is not about concealment.

The sentence you wrote down

Go back to the introduction, where you wrote one sentence you've said on a date that you wouldn't have said if you didn't have a child.

Look at which of the four moves it is. Almost every one of them is one of the four.

That sentence is the habit. You don't need to eliminate it by Friday. You need to hear yourself say it and notice, which is enough to stop it about half the time, and half is a large improvement on where you are.

DO THIS NOW

Write the four moves in your notes: disclose early, pre-answer, discount, over-give. Next time you're talking to someone new, check which one you reached for. Noticing is the entire exercise for the first fortnight.

What this chapter changes

You know what the audition is and why it was costing you information rather than buying you safety.

You're going to need something to do with those early weeks instead. That's the next chapter, and it's the fastest-acting thing in this book.

CHAPTER 3: The Men Who Disqualify Themselves In Week One

Most women screen too late.

Not because they're careless. Because the screening question they're asking is *will he accept my child*, and that question can't be answered in week one, so they wait, and while they wait they get attached, and by the time the answer arrives it costs something to act on.

There's a better question and you can ask it immediately. Not *will he accept my child*. **Is he a person worth telling.**

That one is answerable in a fortnight, from things he says without being prompted.

The six early tells

None of these requires you to have disclosed anything. All of them show up in ordinary conversation.

One. He volunteers a view about single mothers. Unprompted, before he knows anything about you, usually as a general observation. Positive or negative, it doesn't matter. A man with a rehearsed position on a category of women has been in the threads, and you now know where he got his information.

Two. He treats his own family obligations as a burden he's owed credit for. Listen to how he talks about sending money to his mother, or his sister's school fees. Resentment there tells you exactly how he'll talk about your child in eighteen months.

Three. He can't hold a plan. Cancels late, reschedules, reappears warmly. You have less discretionary time than anyone he's dated. A man who wastes it is expensive to you in a way he isn't to other women.

Four. He gets strange about your unavailability. You say you can't on Saturday. Watch whether he's fine, curious, or slightly punished by it. This is the single most predictive tell in the list, because the whole of your life is going to involve you being unavailable sometimes.

Five. He talks about children as an abstraction. *I love kids*. Everyone says it. Ask what his cousin's children are called. The specificity of the answer is the answer.

Six. He's quick to talk about what he'd expect from a partner. Not a red flag on its own. A red flag when it arrives in week one, unprompted, and involves availability.

WHAT NONE OF THESE ARE

None of them is about whether he is a good man, and none is about whether he will love your child. You cannot assess either in two weeks and you should not try. These six tell you one narrow thing: whether he is worth spending the next month on. That is all a filter is for.

Testing number four deliberately

The unavailability tell is worth provoking rather than waiting for, because it costs you nothing and arrives early.

In the first two weeks, decline something once. Not a manufactured drama. An ordinary no.

SCRIPT 1.

"I can't do Saturday. Sunday afternoon works if you're free."

No reason given, and that's the design. You're not lying, you're not disclosing, you're declining and offering an alternative, which is what any adult does.

Three things can happen.

He takes Sunday. Nothing learned except that he's normal, which is worth knowing.

He asks why, lightly, and moves on. Also fine. Curiosity isn't interrogation.

He gets cool, or presses for a reason, or makes a joke with an edge on it. That's your information, in week one, at zero cost. A man who is put out by one ordinary no will not survive a sick child at 11pm.

DO NOT TURN THE FILTER INTO A TRAP

Declining once is a test of his ordinary behaviour. Declining four times to see how much he will tolerate is a game, it is unfair, and it will produce a false result because at some point any reasonable person disengages. Once. Then stop.

What the filter is really buying you

Time, and the order you swapped in Chapter 2.

If he clears the six tells over two or three weeks, you've learned he's worth telling, and the disclosure in Chapter 4 happens from a completely different position. You're not asking whether he'll accept your situation. You're telling someone you've decided is worth it.

If he fails, you've lost a fortnight of texting rather than three months and a conversation with your child about where he went.

YOUR MOVE

1. Write the six tells in your notes.
2. Whoever you're talking to now, mark how many you've already observed.
3. If you've observed two or more, stop reading and go to Chapter 8.
4. If you've observed none, use Script 1 this week.

What this chapter changes

You're screening in week one instead of month three, and you're screening for something that's actually observable.

Which brings the conversation you've been dreading, and the two ways to have it.

CHAPTER 4: Telling Him

You've decided he's worth telling. Now the sentence.

Most women get this wrong in one of two directions. Either it comes out as a confession, delivered with an apology attached, which invites him to respond with reassurance and puts him immediately above you. Or it comes out braced for a fight, flat and slightly hard, which makes a neutral man wonder what he's walked into.

The disclosure is neither. It's information about your life, delivered the way you'd deliver any other large true thing.

Three rules before the wording

Say it before it matters and after it's earned. In practice that's somewhere between the second and fourth time you meet, or when the conversation naturally reaches your life outside work. Not the first hour. Not month three.

Say it once, in one breath, then stop talking. The silence after belongs to him. You've done your part.

Don't attach a disclaimer. No *I know that's a lot*. No *I understand if*. Those are Chapter 2 moves and they undo the sentence they're attached to.

THE WHOLE TECHNIQUE

Say it in exactly the tone you would use to tell him you have a sister. Not heavier. The tone is the message. If your voice drops or rises at the end, you have told him this is a problem, and he will believe you, because you would know.

The warm version

SCRIPT 2. For most situations, and for a man who's cleared the six tells.

"Something you should know about my life. I have a daughter. She's four, she lives with me, and she's the main thing in my life. I don't bring people around her, so this would just be us for a good while. I'm telling you because I'm enjoying this and I'd rather you know now."

Then stop.

Four things are doing work in there. The word *daughter* rather than a vaguer construction, because specificity is confidence. *The main thing in my life*, stated as fact rather than warning. *I don't bring people around her*, which pre-empts the question in Chapter 6 and signals that you have rules. And a reason for telling him now that is about you enjoying it, not about giving him an exit.

Usually provokes: a question or two, then the conversation moves on. That's the common outcome and it surprises women who've been reading the threads.

The firm version

SCRIPT 3. For a man who's already said something about single mothers, or where you've had bad reactions before and want the answer immediately.

"I have a four-year-old. She lives with me and she comes first. That's not going to change, and I'm not looking for anyone to take that on. If that's a problem it's better we know now."

Then stop.

Usually provokes: a clearer answer, faster, and occasionally a defensive *I didn't say it was a problem*. That reaction is fine. It's a man being caught slightly off balance, not a man rejecting you.

Don't lead with this one by default. It's a stronger instrument and it costs a little warmth.

What he does next

He asks normal questions. Age, name, who watches her. Answer them. This is the good outcome and it's more common than you expect.

He says the reassuring thing. *That's fine, I love kids.* Take it as pleasant and nothing more. It's the cheapest sentence in the language and it costs him nothing to say. What matters is behaviour over the next month.

He goes quiet and changes the subject. Let him. Some men need a few days. What you're watching for is whether he comes back to it himself within a week. If he never mentions it again, that's an answer delivered by omission.

He starts negotiating. *So how often would I actually see you?* In week two. He's costing you out before he knows you, which is Chapter 3 tell number six arriving late.

He disappears. It happened in week three instead of month four. That's the filter working, and the only thing you've lost is a fortnight.

THE THING NOT TO DO AFTER

Do not send a follow-up message softening it. Not "sorry if that was heavy", not "no pressure at all", not "I know that's a lot to take in". Every one of those retroactively converts your information into an apology, and you will have undone the entire chapter with one message sent at 11pm because the silence felt long.

DO THIS NOW

Pick your register. Read it aloud four times, with your own child's name and age in it, until it sounds like a fact rather than a speech. If your voice changes on the word "daughter", read it again until it doesn't.

What this chapter changes

You've told him, in a tone that describes your life rather than apologising for it.

What usually comes next isn't rejection. It's questions, and some of them are none of his business.

CHAPTER 5: The Questions That Come After

He took it well. Then, a week later: *so what happened with her dad?*

This is the part nobody prepares you for, because everybody assumes the disclosure is the hard bit. The disclosure is one sentence. The questions go on for months, and the exhausting thing about them is that some are completely reasonable and some are an interrogation, and they arrive in the same tone.

You need a line. Here's where to draw it.

What he's entitled to ask

Three things, and he's entitled to clear answers.

Whether the relationship is over. Fully, unambiguously. Any man dating you has a legitimate interest in knowing there's no live relationship, and you should answer it plainly the first time.

Whether your child's father is present in their life. Not the details. Whether the man exists in your child's week. It affects what dating you looks like.

Whether there's ongoing conflict that will reach him. If there is, he's entitled to know it before he's in it. Wale, 44, told Zikoko that when his girlfriend's children's father found out Wale was spending time with the kids, he "*went berserk*", calling her at odd hours and accusing her of trying to "*replace him*". A man walking into that deserves to know it's there.

That's the list. Three things.

What he isn't entitled to

The full story of how it ended. You may choose to tell him later, and it may be good for you both. He isn't owed it in week five.

Why you chose that man. This question is almost never information-gathering. It's an audit.

Whether you were married. Relevant to a marriage conversation, if you reach one. Not to a fifth date.

Anything about maintenance or money. What your child's father pays or doesn't pay is not a subject for a man who's known you six weeks.

A verdict on him. You are not obliged to run your child's father down to reassure a new man. Women do this to signal loyalty and it always costs more than it buys.

THE DIFFERENCE IN ONE LINE

Questions about your present are fair. Questions about your past are optional. He is entitled to know what he is walking into. He is not entitled to a file.

Answering the fair ones

SCRIPT 4, warm register. The first time he asks about her father.

"It ended about three years ago. He sees her some weekends. There's no drama and nothing between us. If that ever changes you'll hear it from me first."

Short, complete, closes the topic. Usually provokes: satisfaction, and the subject moving on.

SCRIPT 5, firm register. Where there is ongoing conflict and he needs to know.

"We're not together and we won't be. He can be difficult about access and there may be times that spills into my week. I'll tell you when it does. I'm not going to discuss the details of it with you, though, and that's not going to change."

Usually provokes: appreciation for the warning, occasionally a push for detail. Script 6 handles that.

Declining the rest

SCRIPT 6. For the questions he isn't owed, like why you chose him, or how it really ended.

"That's a whole story and it's not one I want to get into. Ask me again in a few months."

Warm, final, and it doesn't slam a door.

If he pushes after that:

"I've told you what matters. The rest is mine."

Usually provokes: a retreat, and often an apology. A man who keeps pushing past that has told you something you should write down.

THE REFLEX TO KEEP TALKING

The dangerous moment is not his question. It is the silence after you decline it. You will feel rude, and the urge to fill the gap with three more sentences of explanation will be strong. Those three sentences are the whole file. Decline, then talk about something else within ten seconds.

When the questions are actually a pattern

Occasionally this isn't curiosity. The tells: the same ground returned to repeatedly, questions that arrive after you've already answered, a tone that treats your history as a character issue, or comparisons to women without children.

That isn't a man getting to know you. That's a man establishing that you're negotiating from behind, and it usually gets worse rather than better.

If you're seeing that, Chapter 8.

YOUR MOVE

Write the three fair questions on one side of a page and the five that aren't on the other. Then write Script 6 underneath. You need that one available in under ten seconds, because it always arrives unexpectedly.

What this chapter changes

You know where the line is and you have wording for both sides of it.

Now the decision you can't take back.

CHAPTER 6: Your Child Is Not A Milestone

Everything else in this book is recoverable.

Tell him too early, you lose a fortnight. Audition, you lose some standing and get it back. Screen badly, you waste a month.

Introduce a man to your child and have him leave four months later, and your child has lost someone. That doesn't get undone by you making a better decision afterwards.

So this chapter has one rule in it, and the rule is the point.

Why it happens too early

Almost never recklessness. Four reasons, all of them sympathetic.

Logistics. Childcare is expensive and your mother can't have them every weekend. Letting him come to the house is easier. The first meeting happens by accident, framed as practicality.

It feels like progress. Four months in, you want a sign that this is going somewhere, and introducing him looks like one.

He asks. Sometimes warmly and with good intentions. *When do I get to meet her?* It sounds like commitment.

You want to know how he'll be with your child. Genuinely the strongest argument on this list, and still not good enough, because you're running the test using your child as the instrument.

THE REFRAKE THAT MAKES THE RULE EASY TO HOLD

Meeting your child is not a stage of your relationship. It is an event in your child's life. Your relationship does not have a right to it, and the fact that things are going well is not a reason. The only reason is that the man is likely to still be there in a year.

The readiness test

Before any introduction. All five, not three of five.

Six months minimum, from the first real date. Not from when you started talking. Chapter 7 is entirely about this.

You've seen him in something difficult. An argument, a setback, bad news, money trouble. You cannot assess a man you've only seen on good days, and your child will meet whoever he is on the bad ones.

He's asked about your child more than once, unprompted, with specificity. Names things. Remembers what you said. Interest that requires no maintenance from you.

You'd be comfortable if your child mentioned him to their other parent. Because they will. If that thought makes you wince, you're not ready, and the reason isn't about him.

You can name what happens if it ends. Not a plan. A sentence. *They'd be sad for a few weeks and I'd tell them he moved away.* If you can't finish that sentence, you haven't thought it through.

Holding the line when he asks

SCRIPT 7.

"I'd like that eventually. I have a rule that people don't meet her until we've been together six months, and it's not about you. She's had enough change. Let's revisit it when we get there."

Three things make it work. *Eventually* is warm and real. *A rule* is impersonal and predates him, which removes the insult. *She's had enough change* is true, unanswerable, and ends the discussion without anyone losing.

Usually provokes: acceptance, often with visible respect. Men who are serious tend to like this, because a woman with rules about her child is a woman with judgement.

Occasionally: *Don't you trust me?* The answer is no, not yet, and you say it kindly.

"It's not about trust. It's about her. Six months isn't long."

The first meeting, when it comes

Short. Neutral ground. Daylight. An hour.

Not at home, because home is hers and you're not handing a stranger the run of it. Not a big outing, because the size of the event tells your child this person is important, and you're not ready to say that.

He's introduced as your friend. Not your boyfriend, whatever he is. The label is for later, and children repeat labels to their fathers, their grandmothers and their teachers.

No sleepovers for a long time afterwards. That's a separate decision with its own timeline and it is much later than most people think.

THE THING THAT DOES THE DAMAGE

It is not one meeting. It is a man who becomes a regular presence and then disappears. Children absorb a stranger at a restaurant fine. What they do not absorb is someone who came every Saturday for five months and then stopped, with no explanation that makes sense to a six-year-old. Everything in this chapter is designed to prevent that one outcome.

When your child doesn't take to him

It happens, and it isn't a verdict on anybody.

Henry, 52, told Zikoko that when his partner asked her children to greet him properly, they wouldn't even pretend to care, and the looks they gave him *"felt like knives"*.

That's an adult describing children protecting themselves, which is what children do.

What it means: go slower. Not that he's wrong for you, and not that your child is being difficult. It means the introduction was earlier than your child was ready for, and the fix is time and lower frequency.

What it doesn't mean: that you should push them together, arrange bonding activities, or ask your child to be polite about it. Pressure at this point produces a child who performs warmth, which is worse than a child who ignores him.

DO THIS NOW

Write the five readiness tests in your notes. Then write today's date next to the six-month one, counting forward from your first real date with whoever you're seeing now. Having the actual calendar date written down is what makes the rule survive a good month.

What this chapter changes

You have a rule, a date, and a sentence for holding it.

The rule only works if you decided it in advance, which is the next chapter.

CHAPTER 7: The Six-Month Rule

Rules made on a Tuesday survive. Rules made in the moment do not.

That's the entire argument of this chapter. Chapter 6 gave you a rule about your child. This one is about making sure it's still standing in month four, when things are going well, when he's been patient, when your mother is unavailable on Saturday and letting him come round would solve everything.

You will not hold that line by being strong. You'll hold it because you decided it in advance and wrote it down.

Why six

Not because six is magic. Because of what six months contains that three doesn't.

A disagreement, resolved or not. At least one period where one of you was under pressure. A stretch of ordinary weeks with no novelty in them. Enough time for a man who's performing to get tired of performing, which takes most people about four months.

Three months tells you how he is when it's new. Six tells you how he is.

If you want a different number, pick one and write down why. The number matters less than the fact that you set it before you needed it.

The checklist

One page in your notes. Write it tonight, before you're in a situation where you'd rather not.

My rules, decided [date]:

- He doesn't meet my child before [actual calendar date]
- He doesn't come to my house while my child is there before then
- He isn't "uncle" or "daddy" anything, at any point, until I say so
- My child isn't mentioned by name on his social media, ever, and not in photos
- If we split, I tell my child [what], within [how long]
- I tell their other parent that someone is around before they hear it from my child

That last one saves more trouble than everything above it combined. Wale, 44, described a children's father who *"went berserk"* on finding out a new man was spending time with his kids, and accused the mother of trying to *"replace him"*. Some of that is unavoidable. A lot of it is about how he found out.

WHY WRITING IT DOWN WORKS WHEN DECIDING DOES NOT

In month four you will not be deciding whether to introduce them. You will be deciding whether to override a decision you already made, and those are psychologically different acts. The written rule does not make you stronger. It changes what you are being asked to do.

The conversation with a man who is waiting well

If he's cleared six months and the readiness tests, say so directly. Waiting deserves acknowledgement.

SCRIPT 8.

"You've been patient about this and I've noticed. I think we're at the point where you two can meet. I want to keep it short and low-key the first time, just an hour somewhere neutral, and she'll know you as my friend. Is that alright with you?"

Usually provokes: pleasure, and often relief. It also quietly tests one last thing, because a man who argues with *short, neutral, my friend* at this stage is telling you he wants the status more than the relationship.

When the rule is the problem

Sometimes a good man struggles with it, and it's worth distinguishing two things.

He's disappointed. Normal. He likes you, he wants in, waiting is not fun. Disappointment that passes in a day is not a warning about anything.

He treats the rule as a verdict on him. Returns to it repeatedly, frames it as you not trusting him, uses it as evidence you're not serious. That isn't disappointment. That's a man who has decided your child's stability is an obstacle to his timeline, and he's shown you that in month four rather than month fourteen, which is useful.

THE EXCEPTION YOU ARE ALREADY DRAFTING

There is a version of this where the rule bends. Your child is ill and he's the only person who can drive you. Your mother cancels. Something genuinely unforeseeable. One emergency is life. What you should watch for is the second one, because the second emergency is usually not an emergency, and by the third the rule is gone and nobody ever decided to remove it.

DO THIS NOW

Write the six-line checklist into your notes with the actual dates filled in. Title it something dull. Then set one calendar reminder for the six-month date. Not to act on. Just so the date arrives rather than drifts.

What this chapter changes

The rule exists outside your head, with dates on it, which means month four is an override rather than a decision.

That covers the man who stays. The last chapter is for the one who doesn't.

IN PRACTICE: Four Months, Start To Finish

Everything so far has been one decision at a time. Here is the whole sequence running, so you can see the shape of it.

This is a composite. It is not one woman's story and no real person is described. Every move in it is a move from the previous chapters, put in the order they actually arrive.

Week one

She matches with him. He's 34, works in logistics, conversation is easy.

She doesn't mention her daughter. Not hiding it, just not leading with it, which is the Chapter 2 swap.

On day five he suggests Saturday. She uses Script 1.

"I can't do Saturday. Sunday afternoon works if you're free."

He says Sunday's better for him anyway.

That's tell four cleared, at zero cost, in week one. Before this book she'd have explained that Saturdays are hard because of childcare, which would have disclosed everything and taught him she was working around an obstacle.

Weeks two and three

Two more meetings. She's watching the six tells and not much else.

He mentions his mother twice. Both times about calling her, not about money. No resentment in it.

He reschedules once, three days ahead, with an actual reason. That's not tell three, which is about lateness and pattern.

He says nothing about single mothers, because nothing has come up.

Three tells cleared, none tripped. She's not in love. She's decided he's worth telling, which is a much smaller decision and the only one available at three weeks.

Week four

Over lunch, the conversation reaches her life outside work. She uses Script 2.

"Something you should know about my life. I have a daughter. She's four, she lives with me, and she's the main thing in my life. I don't bring people around her, so this would just be us for a good while. I'm telling you because I'm enjoying this and I'd rather you know now."

Then she stops talking.

He asks her daughter's name and who looks after her during the week. She answers both in one sentence each and asks him something else.

What she doesn't do: explain that her daughter is well behaved, say she understands if it's a lot, or apologise for the timing. All four audition moves, all declined.

That evening she wants to send a message softening it. She doesn't, which is the hardest thirty seconds of the whole four months.

Week six

He asks what happened with her daughter's father.

Fair question, first time asked. Script 4.

"It ended about three years ago. He sees her some weekends. There's no drama and nothing between us. If that ever changes you'll hear it from me first."

He nods and the conversation moves on.

Two weeks later he asks why she was with him in the first place. That one isn't on the entitled list. Script 6.

"That's a whole story and it's not one I want to get into. Ask me again in a few months."

He says fair enough. The silence afterwards lasts about four seconds and she talks about something else, which is the technique.

Month three

He asks when he'll meet her daughter.

This is the moment the whole book is built around, and it arrives sounding like commitment, at a point where things are going well and saying no feels ungrateful. Script 7.

"I'd like that eventually. I have a rule that people don't meet her until we've been together six months, and it's not about you. She's had enough change. Let's revisit it when we get there."

He's disappointed for an evening. By the next day it's gone.

She holds it because the date is written in her notes with the checklist from Chapter 7, decided in week four when nothing was at stake. She isn't deciding whether to introduce them. She's deciding whether to override herself, and that's a different and much harder thing to talk herself into.

Month four

Her mother cancels on a Saturday. He offers to come over.

This is the exception she drafted in advance, and she recognises it as one. It isn't an emergency. It's an inconvenience wearing an emergency's clothes.

She says no and pays for a sitter she can't really afford. It costs her about a day's pay, and it saves the rule.

WHAT THE SEQUENCE ACTUALLY SHOWS

Not one of those moves required courage in the moment. Every one of them was decided in advance, written down, and then executed on a day when she was tired. That is the only reason any of it held. Willpower is not the mechanism here and it never was.

Where it goes from there

Two ways.

He clears six months, the readiness tests in Chapter 6 all pass, and there's an hour in a neutral place where a four-year-old meets her mother's friend and finds him unremarkable.

Or he doesn't, and she finds out in month five rather than month eighteen, and her daughter never knew he existed.

Both of those are wins. Only one of them looks like one at the time.

CHAPTER 8: When He Will Not Choose You

Two ways this ends badly, and they look nothing alike.

One is loud and quick. He hears about your child and goes. That one hurts for a fortnight and costs you almost nothing, and everything in Chapters 3 and 4 is designed to make it happen early.

The other is quiet and expensive. He stays. For a year, two years. He's fond of you, he's around, and he never quite arrives. There's always a reason the timing isn't right, and the reason is never your child, and it's always your child.

The second one is the reason this chapter exists.

The man who stays and never commits

He tells, and they're consistent.

He hasn't introduced you to anyone who matters to him. Not family, not close friends, after a year or more.

Your child is never mentioned in any sentence about the future. He'll talk about next year, about a trip, about a plan, and your child isn't in it. Not excluded. Just absent, every time.

He's warm about your child and disengaged from them. Asks how they are. Never asks anything specific, never remembers what you said last week.

And when you raise where this is going, the answer is always about circumstances. Work, money, his family, timing. Never about wanting or not wanting.

That's not a man deciding slowly. That's a man who has decided and would rather not say it, because saying it would end something comfortable.

THE ONLY TEST THAT WORKS HERE

Stop reading his behaviour and give him a date. Not an ultimatum and not a deadline he knows about. A date in your own notes, three months out. If nothing concrete has moved by then, you have your answer, and you got it without ever having to make him confess.

Ending it

SCRIPT 9, warm register. For a man who's been decent and simply isn't going to get there.

"I've been thinking about this for a while. I don't think we want the same thing, and I can't keep waiting to find out. I'm not angry with you and I've been happy. I just need to stop."

Usually provokes: sadness, sometimes a promise that things will change. If you want to test that promise, test it with three months of visible change, not with a conversation.

SCRIPT 10, firm register. For the man who's been keeping you available.

"This has been going on two years and nothing has moved. I'm not going to discuss it again or negotiate it. I'm done."

Usually provokes: anger first, then a message four to eight weeks later that opens warmly. You'll recognise it. You don't have to answer it.

What you tell your child

Only if your child met him. If they didn't, there's nothing to say and you're allowed your privacy.

If they did: short, true, and not about you. *He's not going to be coming round anymore. It's nothing you did. I'm fine.*

Don't invite them to be sad with you, and don't keep asking how they feel about it, which teaches them it was a large event. Answer questions if they ask. Say the same thing each time.

They'll ask about him once or twice over the following months, usually at an inconvenient moment, and then stop.

The other parent, and where this book stops

If your child's father is obstructing you, threatening you, or withholding access to punish you because there's a new man around, that has left the territory of dating advice entirely.

Access, custody and maintenance are legal matters wherever you live, with real remedies. A book cannot advise you on them and this one won't try. Speak to a lawyer. Most African countries have a free legal aid body for people who cannot afford one, including Nigeria's Legal Aid Council, Ghana's Legal Aid Commission, Kenya's National Legal Aid Service and Legal Aid South Africa. Your ministry for women or gender affairs can also refer you.

That's an ordinary step, not a dramatic one, and taking it early is much cheaper than taking it late.

WHEN IT IS NOT A DATING PROBLEM AT ALL

If a partner has threatened you, monitored you, controlled your money, or made you afraid, that is abuse and no chapter of this book applies to it. In Lagos, the Domestic and Sexual Violence Agency runs a free, confidential 24-hour line on 08000 333 333, with counselling, legal support and access to shelter. Wherever else you are, findahelpline.com lists free, confidential services by country, and your ministry for women or gender affairs, or the police gender desk, can refer you. If any of this describes your situation, that call matters more than anything else in these pages.

The thing that is actually true

Kaffy, the woman who was told she couldn't be dated because of her two children, said something else on that podcast:

"Real love brings peace not butterflies. Real love is not supposed to make you anxious."

That's a woman who's been through the version of this that everybody warns you about, and the standard she came out with is higher than the one she went in with, not lower.

YOUR MOVE

If you're in the second situation, the quiet one, put a date in your notes three months from today. Write one line next to it: what would have to have actually changed. Then close the note and don't look at it until the date.

What this chapter changes

You can tell the two endings apart, you have words for both, and you know which problems belong to a lawyer rather than a book.

CONCLUSION: The Room You Were Never In

Go back to the count.

Five Nigerians interviewed about dating someone with a child. Three men dating mothers, two women dating fathers. Not one of them the parent.

That's where you started this book, and it's the shortest way to say what's wrong with everything published about your situation. The conversation is real, it's ongoing, and you've been outside it reading through the window.

What changed

You stopped treating fifteen years of forum argument as evidence about yourself. You recognised the audition and swapped the order, so you find out about him before you tell him about you. You screen in week one on six things you can actually observe. You have a sentence for telling him, a line around your child's father, a rule about your child with a real date on it, and two ways to end it.

None of that required anyone's permission, which is the point. Every decision in this book was always yours. They were just being discussed elsewhere as though they weren't.

THE WHOLE BOOK IN THREE SENTENCES

The debate about whether you are worth dating is conducted by people with nothing at stake, and you have been treating their conclusions as facts about your life. The decisions that matter are all yours: who to screen out, when to tell, and when your child meets anyone. Make them in advance, in writing, and you will keep them when it counts.

Tonight

Three things, and none of them takes twenty minutes.

Write the six tells from Chapter 3 into your notes.

Write the six-line checklist from Chapter 7, with the actual calendar date on the first line.

And read Script 2 out loud four times, with your own child's name in it, until it sounds like a fact rather than a confession.

That last one is the whole book compressed into an exercise. The tone you say it in is what you believe about it, and your child can hear the difference, and so can he.

You were never the topic. You're the one deciding.

Sources: Kaffy on The Honest Bunch podcast (August 2025); Wale and Henry in Zikoko's 5 Nigerians on Dating Partners With Kids; matchmaking prices via Pulse Nigeria (August 2026). Helplines were correct at the time of writing.

The Connection Code